

Simul:
An Examination of the Faithfulness of The Doctrine's
Theological Anthropology

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Introduction

This paper will examine Simul - in particular, Simul Justus Et Peccator, which means that a person is a saint and just and a sinner at the same time. The cited sources are often regarding the controversy surrounding this doctrine - the Orthodox, Catholic, vs Protestant view. Many sources try to resolve this conflict to create a kind of ecumenical statement. I honestly believe that most debates in this vain are just different views of definitions of words.

Am I good or evil? It is scary to think that I am completely evil and totally depraved. It is happy to think that I am good and loved by God.

How should I view myself? Am I just? Or am I a sinner? This is the topic of this paper, and I want to state as my thesis: Orthodox views on justification seem to present a new view point on Luther's perspective, and the Catholics seem to disagree on how Christ's justification is dispensed, but all agree that Christ's justification is what saves us - it is Christ alone, which we all believe.

It has been said that the ecumenical movement is illegitimate. What I mean is that only a few Christians and parts of the Protestants and few Catholics actually want to get together and unite. Thus, as we see in the document, *The Joint Declaration of the Doctrine of Justification*,¹ we see there is a group of Anti-JDDJ and Pro-JDDJ proponents.

One of the points of division is that in 1547, "there was a clear statement that human actions in no way bring about justification." This is a point that

"still, Roman Catholic teaching in the post-tridentine time continued to ascribe good works with some kind of efficacy. In many ways, on the issue of justification both churches continued to pass each other like ships in the night."

We can see that the classical division between Catholics and Protestants is at hand with the issue of justification and with Simul.

As I will explain, Simul Justus Et Peccator means that we are just but sinners at the same time. It means that we are justified and right with God and have the righteousness of Christ, but are still sinners.

I'd like to further define and clarify this doctrine by stating my view that this doctrine means that we cannot do anything good on our own accord, and that if anything good is done, it is through Jesus Christ, not us.

¹ Lutheran World Federation and Roman Catholic Church, *Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans Publishing Company, 2000).

And thus, Romans says the Spirit lives in us and works in us. We must yield our lives to Christ and to the Spirit and by doing so, we are able to live a righteous life.

The point that the Reformers are making in terms of theological anthropology is that there is nothing good in us when we look at ourselves and in our own strength.

It's essentially like the Heisenberg Uncertainty Principle - if I see it, it is false.

What it is saying is that the Spirit and God are invisible and not controlled by man. Thus, when a person is moved or filled by the Holy Spirit, it is not the working of will of man (Peter - in terms of prophecies), it is God.

Thus, we have nothing to do but to yield ourselves to the Spirit.

And this is where the division between Catholics and Christians come in: what does it mean to yield ourselves to the Spirit?

Does it mean: simply have faith and do nothing? That is the view of the Protestants. "All our righteous deeds are like dirty rags," Isaiah says, and thus, we cannot do anything, and are totally depraved, and thus, we must simply do nothing or just wait for the Holy Spirit.

But Catholics define yielding to the Holy Spirit in a positive sense: to do the sacraments and to do the will of God. It is through the Church rituals that we are saved.

And to this, Luther proclaimed, "It is only Christ alone, through faith alone, through Scripture alone, not the Catholic Church."

As the document cited says, "Through Christ alone are we justified."

The document states that in the "new millennium, the very depth and breadth of the term justification raises questions which Luther, Calvin, and the bishops of Trent never thought about."

One of the issues that I can bring up that hasn't been thought of, as far as I know is, if it is truly

through Christ alone that we are saved, then shouldn't we be focusing on the salvation of souls as the primary goal of Christians and the church?

Jesus said to make disciples of all nations - this is evangelism.

Once a person is saved, he has Christ, and then Christ will guide him for the rest of his life whether he has Scripture or the church or not.

Like Luther said, it is Christ alone, not the church or Scripture, just Christ.

This type of thinking would radically remove all religion and replace it with simply the Spirit of Christ, which is simply that a Spirit, not a religion.

Even Luther wouldn't expect that for his Christianity. This would further emphasize that all religion is man-made and that the anthropology of man simply needs the Spirit of Christ, not some good works or church.

And the church is good, but Christ is all in all and the only.

The second source I want to examine is: *An Orthodox Perspective on the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification*². And this document looks at the Orthodox Church's view of all this.

"The Orthodox Church has never in its own history made the relationship between grace and works a soteriological question." What this means is that grace and works has not been thought of as an important issue in their church. According to the document, even since the Pelagian crisis Eastern Christianity displayed a lack of interest in justification.

What the document says is that Orthodox teaching does not accept original sin. You see, they teach that although we are tainted by sin, we can still have the Free Will to choose good or evil. We do not inherit the guilt of Adam. This is an important theological anthropological claim.

² **Julija Vidović**, "An Orthodox Perspective on the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification," *The Ecumenical Review* **71**, no. 3 (2019): 280–295.

And to this, I will say, there is nothing wrong per say. But it definitely is a challenge to total depravity. It is essentially saying I can do good things and I through the Spirit can choose good.

This is an incredibly different viewpoint and must be examined. It was Pelagius who first said this, I believe, and I must say I cannot definitely say that he is wrong because I want to be open-minded.

I think that a desire to think that I am completely bad is sinful as well, because God made me in the Image of God, as the Orthodox people say.

Thus, the Orthodox would say that I am Just because I can choose good, and Sinner because I can choose sin - I am neither only good nor bad.

And I'm blown away by this because this contradicts Luther completely!

And this doctrine completely frees me by saying, "Hey Dennis, you are a good person too! Good luck and work hard because you can do the right thing! Be free!"

Luther is constantly thinking about his sin, but Orthodox teaching says just be free.

A third viewpoint can be that we are only good because Christ is in us.

This is a radical view that I just made up, but I must say, it is biblical because I am just. My true nature is good, but my old nature is bad, but I am my true nature not my old nature, so I am completely good.

This radically frees me to love myself.

With Luther's theology, I would hate myself.

The third source is by Turner³. Turners says that some Catholics were thought to have abandoned the Council of Trent and some Lutherans sold out to Catholicism by signing the JDDJ.

But Simul Justus Et Peccator was a doctrine that was conserved on both sides, according to Turner because Catholics said that salvation comes through baptism and Lutherans said no. However, both sides agreed that salvation comes from God.

And to this I want to say, does salvation come through sacraments? That can only be believed if the Catholic is the True Church that has the authority to dispense salvation.

But Luther said Scripture is all there is.

And I say, it is Christ alone.

But what this says about anthropology is that we are in need of salvation. Do we need the sacraments or a dose of salvation daily or weekly? Or is it finished and one time done?

I believe it is finished and one time done. The Bible says we are justified and glorified and Jesus says it is finished. Thus, we don't have to go around looking for salvation or the next sacrament - we are completely free to live out our salvation.

In conclusion, I believe I am Just - only Just, and that Sin is in me, but is not part of my identity. I agree with the Orthodox viewpoint that I am able to do good or bad, but I take it a step further and say that if I do bad, it is not me who is doing it, but sin that is in me, as Romans 7 says.

But I understand the controversy regarding this viewpoint, and I say that it is Christ who makes a person righteous.

But I really believe that we should love ourselves and not hate ourselves for our sin. Luther was known to be too harsh on himself for his sin, and I think that is a flaw we should not copy.

³ Max Turner, "Rereading Paul Together: Protestant and Catholic Perspectives on Justification," (Publisher, 2008), **151–152**.